Like all parents, we had occasional problems with the children. All four children had minds of their own, and in different ways they all were capable of expressing their independence. Ron and Maureen showed that when they demanded I act more decisively about the Iran-Contra situation. I'd always encouraged the children to speak their minds.

I suspect it's never easy for children who grow up in a family with celebrities, and I'm sure that the added prominence that fell on the shoulders of the children after I was elected president didn't make their lives any easier. Ron and Patti at times were especially unhappy about having to submit to round-the-clock Secret Service protection, which became especially tight after the CIA received reports of terrorist attacks planned against me and my family. And the prominence of my job may have exacerbated a problem for Michael. During the years I was president, Mike started having difficulty coming to terms with the fact that he was adopted. Although I'd always given him as much love as the other children, he suddenly found it difficult to live with the fact that he was adopted and felt worthless because of it. His wife, Colleen, tried to convince him he had no reason for this concern, but it really weighed heavily on his mind, and as a result, after I'd call or see him to find out whether I could work out the problem, we had several confrontations in which he accused me of not loving him. Then something happened that was almost a miracle: He decided to write a book about his life that became a catharsis for dealing with the problems that had bothered him. After Mike and Colleen brought their children, Cameron and Ashley, to the ranch for one visit, I wrote in my diary: "It was a new Mike. He's writing a book and it has led to a soul searching about himself which resulted in a confession of how he had done things to all of us and that he now saw himself as he had been and what he wanted to be." Later, when I read his